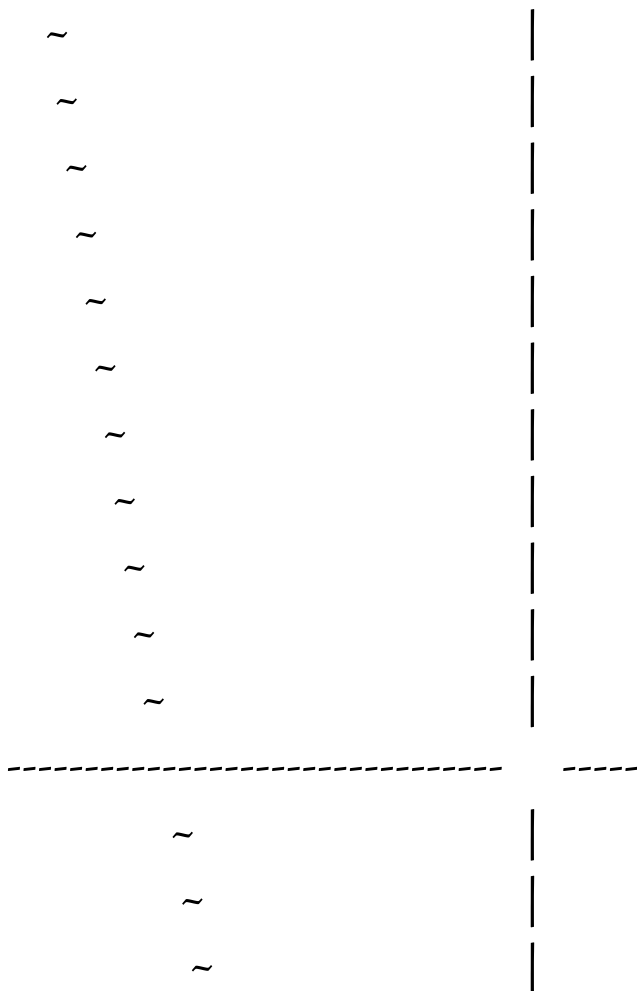


Their Most August Public Organ



Craig Warren Smith



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A portion of this novel first appeared
in Pocketbook journal (2026) as
'Observer at Fixed Distance'.

The moral rights of the author have,
to a cursory extent, been somewhat asserted.

www.wrenasmir.com

2026



Abrachas Publishing



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/ROOT

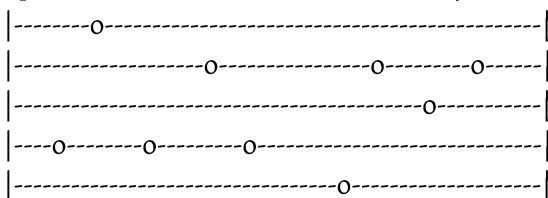
README.txt

For an unabridged recording of this book,
and to read it online, visit novel.wrenasmir.com

The hand, which tolerates no chance, transforms a living system into a controllable object and invents the wilderness in order to subjugate it.

From *Total Refusal*, Trailer 25.

At meaning's edge the imagination still flickers. It is jigsaw daylight between shy evergreen canopies. I am on my way to see my friend. The train is steady and the sky is both very far above us and lying flat against these knife grazed panels of pause. Through the window south of Newcastle over a river now I see iron matrices, long pylons like bar lines
| | | | | | | and they
resonate a phasing of bass notes against the floor of the carriage in an ostinato that tinkers upwards and south on a known wobbly offbeat



that I hummmm and start assigning words to.

Were the notation to be seen from above, like sideways music, flat beneath the feet, the notes could well be markers for a shifting of weight left and right like The Boxer used to write me in letters during a Summer past. Knees slightly bent, light on the ball as you drop to the heel and pivot east and then west and back and repeat east on a hop like a hi hat paradiddle. The Boxer used to write me although I had no fixed address, nor did he for that matter. I'd get a sense of a pub on the regional plains that he was moving towards and I'd write the letter in that direction, I suppose. So too he'd intimate that I was sleeping on one or another couch of one or another girl who had taken me in over the Summer, if not on a golf course or beachhead or rooftop during the balmy nights, of which they all were other than when loneliness dropped the degrees and sideways music could be heard all at once from one or another balcony before, during and after, forever and ever, or so it seemed. I read so many paperbacks from the pulp of Australia's twentieth century output that Summer, of which I transcribed paragraphs for The Boxer.

Some of the paragraphs were ones I later worked on with Katita to compress into text files on the mesh networks we set up across regional plains not dissimilar to those The Boxer traversed with the courtesan he invited on the road with him. Occasionally I thought I recognised a place from his letters, even if only from all the negative space. At the time, that Summer, when I was a layabout couch surfer, reclining everywhere my body could fall into, be it fabric or sand, flesh or grass, being or time, I always had a paperback with me, bought with loose change from the Cooks Hill Bookstore. They were always Australian novels and almost all just skirting the war years, books anticipating a generational event for a country that seemed perpetually to be waiting for its part in a story being told elsewhere. I wanted the people in these stories to spend longer in their kitchens and to occupy larger imaginative backyards, although whenever the book gave them more I began looking for signs of what was coming to take it all away. Characters were often waiting for a letter, and when it arrived it made a sound like radio crackle. The letters would be for me also, containing instructions and fair questions.

The weight of imagination feels like it occupies a lower frequency of mass than it once did. I say this whilst looking out the window and projecting fictions onto the glass like a transparent comic strip panel with a backlit panorama of outskirts tundra rushing past as a zoetrope would animate a galloping horse. I can see Katita there, papers spread across her knees, the corners weighted with things from her pockets, rocks and batteries. One of my letters to The Boxer lay beside a passage I had copied from a book. Katita had marked a sentence in both, cross-referencing my handwritten sprawl. She kept turning a little screw between her fingers while I explained how much room the imagination needed, how a person might require an entire afternoon and quite a considerable area of grass or grass-adjacent bedding. There were several difficulties of the age, all this surplus of the seen, that I thought we might approach once we all had somewhere quiet to sit. This is what I told The Boxer, in letters, and what Katita later kindly shrugged at, touching my face with her flower dusted palm to confirm I was still maintaining adequate physical form.

Katita slept in fields of flannel and everlasting daisies and billy buttons and mulla mulla beneath variations of daylight and noon while I fed the data she prepared into solar powered memory casings. These devices transmitted a low-power signal that anyone with a wireless device from the past twenty years could log onto and download all manner of documents across three hundred bits per second, such as

/ROOT

index.html

README.txt

/audio

River_NSW_1500hrs_Late20thCent.mp3

AlfredHill_StringQuartet5_Allegro.mp3

/text

TomMaguire_Extracts.txt

Impressionism_BushStudies.txt

Graves_TimeAndDirection_1952_Notes.txt

/images

Photo_ServiceStation_Dusk_NSW_1993.jpg

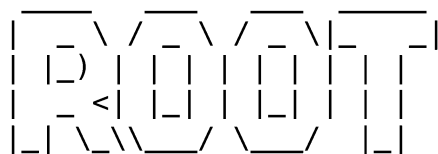
Photo_MotelFan_Shadow_1987.jpg

Plate_EucalyptusLeaf_Study_BW.png

Spectrogram_RiverAnomaly.png

housed most often in the burlled knots of trees, a loose bark plate shielding the rod transceiver.

Trees are preferable sites for hosting the LCD interfaces for any number of reasons, not least that attaching them to any sort of public infrastructure be it a council toilet block or a No Parking sign always gets them cut down, or in the worst instance when we placed one beneath a picnic table in an overgrown Lions Club park beside a sandy creek bed outside of Muswellbrook we had a bomb squad turn up to dismantle the hardware and almost give the whole thing away. Fortunately it was assumed to be a GeoCache device or part of an online game and that was the end of it. When they saw the resting screen dialogue, a variation of



NODE ACTIVE

CONNECT: ROOT-LOCAL

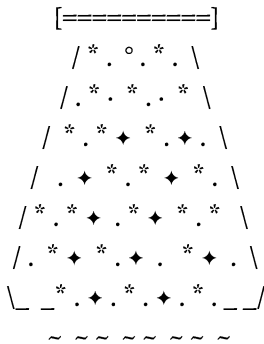
ARCHIVE AVAILABLE

Katita heard one of the squad say Hey is this how Tindr operated in the nineties and they laughed and then someone accidentally or not stepped on the device and they drove away and Katita and I agreed - no more Lions Clubs.

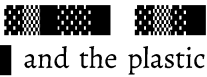
But that's not the reason we decided to only stick them in trees going forward. Katita and I had experimented with putting them anywhere you can imagine on our trips across the basin, including the rooftops of any number of abandoned motels we stayed at, and they worked well enough and didn't alert the authorities. You can still find them up there today, ten years on. The signals still pulse. Between the solar and the batteries in them they will last for another fifty years, longer than the motels will be standing for, which is another reason to choose trees, although not the prime reason. If you are travelling within view of the Darling River I'll give you a challenge. First find one of the motels without fee. You'll know them because the reception areas are a bed of pigeon disjecta and due notices. Check the meter box to ensure the service fuse is removed and look at the bulbs, all sun-bleached and insect infused, in the mildew ceilings. On the second floor there will be a bedroom with a window open. Look down and there will be a gravel yard with a templated oil drum that used to house fire beside empty tins of soup and chilli con carne.

Step carefully onto the ledge of the window sill and only pull down enough weight on the guttering with your hands to steady yourself before finding better grip on the wooden eaves or better yet a necklace of bricks that sit beneath the roof tiles. Leverage yourself up and look over the enormity of nationhood for a couple of seconds before reaching for the weatherproof mesh distributor and hook up your phone or your MP3 player or e-reader or even the east to west scrolling blue resonance of car radio media housing if the aux can jack into enough of a signal on the breeze. It'll all be there, our small town eucalyptus version of Voyager's Golden Records, containing enough archival text, sound and imagery to help any young Blinky Bill character out there on the road after the collapse of civilisation to review and remember what once was, not so it can be rebuilt, but so it can be reevaluated in the light of whatever the potential of tomorrow could be at its highest estimation. Ten years on that feels like a quaint thing to say, yet looking out the window just now at the empty platform at Fassifern, there is little I'd rather live again than slow cooking chilli con carne with Katita.

There was a time she used to wear a hologram skirt in palm tree food courts across the pinball coast of the northern seaboard while I appeared as no less than a mostly futureproof amplified bushranger wearing a jetpack and a grevillea boutonnière. If you imagine Katita's skirt as a flickering incandescent starfield like



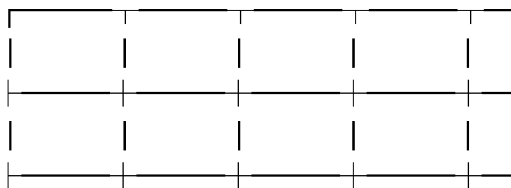
you might picture a cinematic beaker full of magic, but actually it was much more like a beach scene, no different to the pleated palm tree glisten above, a shifting of biogenic light, $\backslash/ \quad _ \backslash/ _$ like graph theory trees, those $/ \backslash \quad | \quad \backslash/$ series-reduced problems that $| \quad | \quad / \backslash$ mathematicians like to solve, $| \quad | \quad |$ the same reason trees housed our ROOT hardware, because the vertices were botanical antennas of incomparable diffusion.

We read the menu together in the food court.
 All the text on the boards was written in neon,
 not just the major categories of food or big
 illuminated names of a given establishment,
 the sides too, the disco fries and half-dreamed
 haloumi, all blinking like the LED gaps nestled
 in the carpeted ceiling of function rooms in
 nineteen eighties leagues clubs, like the dot
 matrix ocean of glitter rising from Katita's
 skirt, I bring my eyes back to the menu, we
 stand dazed and read and re-read the options.
 The palm fronds kept waving in front of key
 words that would have determined if we were
 ordering chips or chops, and the pastel sky
 kept under-saturating the pizza toppings. At
 the risk of waiting too long to make a decision
 and finding ourselves in an empty paradise of
 Kodachrome fountains spilling static cascades
 of sweet nothing, Katita pointed to the only
 complete neon sentence visible during the last
 hour of our time there together, unbeknownst
 to us at that point, asking  and the plastic
 robotic burger-kin taking our order emoted
 「● ^ ●」 ? and Katita asked again Can we
 please have Their Most August Public Organ.

When the bushranger with a jetpack was oh say a younger lad of five he would follow his parents into the video store where his mother and father would get ten old VHS rentals for a week at a bundled discount of five dollars, a bargain compared to the new releases that could cost the same for one video with an overnight return. Before the five-year-old bushranger, pre-beard and with only a miniature jetpack strapped to his back the size of a cereal box, would get to the shelves of videos, he would stop by the wall of Sega Master System game boxes and scan his eyes across them like he was moving between squares on a map, identifying coordinates that would later take on the form of paving blocks in the quiet sunlit backyards of the long afternoon of his childhood, which he would step back and forth across while imagining the many different dimensions and narratives these game worlds might manifest as. This was by far the apogee of enjoyment the boy extracted from video games, seeing as he didn't own a console himself it was by inhabiting a spectrum of potential that he was able to harvest this most pure realisation of virtual joy.

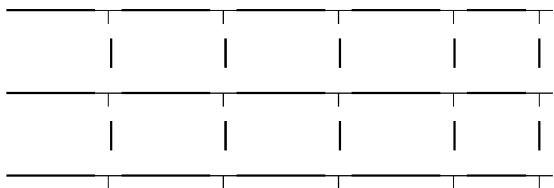
I owe my daydream capacity to the structure and persistence of suburban backyards during the postwar years. Not just those of the homes I lived in but also those of grandparents and the yards my mother and father would tend to for elderly folks in the community. Every tidy sunlit corner where concrete meets soil, every aviary and white painted wrought iron table and chair, every tiered fold of downhill lawn, every shed and garage with shadow boards for tools with sturdy wooden handles above a bench with a clamp and a wireless and a milk crate to sit on beneath a naked globe and read the handwritten quotes in block letters on corrugated cardboard in thick black texta such as I Was Sad I Had No Shoes Until I Met A Man Who Had No Feet or, in one particular garage of a local boxing historian who is no longer with us, I remember becoming engrossed in a paperback he'd written about different fighters from our region. The story of one of them, Elias Shore, told how he had to be promoted as a Cuban boxer because his birthright as a First Nations man was not palatable with local sensibilities at the time. Not long after this I first heard from the man I would call The Boxer.

Thinking about those Sega Master System game boxes in the video store, the blue grid on the front cover they all used to wear, mostly blank with only limited graphical information so the customer would pick up the box and turn it over to see what the game was all about and, with physical touch engaged, hopefully see that box taken to the checkout, reminded me of the tartan picnic blankets that Katita would snooze atop during daytime operations



but because I'm thinking of The Boxer now I think of his partner and the coalfield taverns they'd occupy instead, the way he would sit in a wing chair on the opposite side of the room and watch her sleep. She had auburn teak hair like old rockets made from trees, the same as Katita and her infinite ponytail, same brown as those seemingly endless lounges that all my girlfriends would let me sleep on during that distant Summer when they let me ramble and smiled like it wasn't a problem like it became.

Love is everything you know not to say. Love is every secret you take to the grave. Love is all you can't give to someone who can't receive it. Love is the pen that has no ink in the hand of one who cannot write because love is what occurs before the existence of words. Love is a private beach with no possible access points. Love is knowing you cannot be saved. Love is need multiplied by yearning. Love is a fence obscured by the scale of an overgrown garden.



Let me tell you about the friend I'm going to see who, from here on, I'll always refer to as my friend, as in, I am on my way to see my friend. We see each other every six months or so. It was just after New Year that we took our most recent walk together, in bushland like the one we're headed to this morning. On that day we embraced as we will on this day too, as brothers who survived the teenage years, the courting years, the apprentice years, and now the middle-years of our anticipated lifespans.

We will park outside the bush as always and then my friend will drive us in his capable four-wheel drive across the first ridge of the mountain that necklaces the region. There will

/ \	be a clutter of wrens as ever,
/ \	their feet tussling with a soft
/ ^^ \	carriage of green air and bell
/ / \ \	swoop, wrens that seemingly
/ __ Mountain __ \	rise out of wrens, trees out
	of the canopy of other trees,
X - + -	as we get out at this position.
START	Behind the mountain proper,
^^	we start on a descension of
/ \	some two kilometres along
	a trail that used to be a segment
+ - Radar - +	of the Great North Walk until
Station	it became too abandoned, and
^^	maybe too that the radar station
^^ / \ \	has invested forever chemicals
/ \ \	rendering the trees a shade of
/ \ \	transparent rust that further
Church	triplicates the wrens as if the
Ruins	bush is a mirror, which it is,
†	the ruins of the church doing
X	their part to commemorate an
FINISH	emphatic desire for symbols.

No symbols where none intended, we do nonetheless turn the internal geography of our twin subjectivities towards the landscape that surrounds us. The mountains become reasons for overcoming, the radar station elicits its war roots, the trees their capacity to communicate through mycorrhizal networks of fungal threads, the wood wide web, to say nothing of their own airborne radar signals, trees smelling other trees for chemical alert, root and filament inflamed in consciousness, then onto the fallen stones of the church that is now structured as an arboretum, windows sharded with bark wrapped in vines, leaf crumble in the pulpit. Bach used to write organ fugues in accordance with the geometry of the church they would be played in. So too this church, filled with wind and bird holler. My friend and I talk about the twentieth century, mostly. We start with the death of god and move onto the wars, the moral thread of meaning and care that becomes more worn and vacant the further time gets beyond the wars, beyond the end of all history, towards a nihilism that we feel at the base and apogee of all honest attempts of sense making and grace.

My friend asked me, on our last walk together, how Katita was, and I told him that by all reports she was going well with her project. He asked me when the last time was that I saw her and I changed the subject. I asked him about his new squeeze and he told me not to call her that. Then he said his squeeze was doing well, they were moving in together shortly, and when I asked what she looked like, as I still hadn't met her, he said she was the spitting image of the tattoo of a mermaid on his chest, even down to the tail as she wore an emerald pant suit for work, it was uncanny like as if the tattoo was a talisman that sent a homing signal out to the lifelike human version of the image. I told him that this reminded me of something that happened to me recently. It was a warm night and I rode my bike to the ocean baths for a nocturnal dip. A few scattered others were there but it was after ten at night so barely anyone around really. I floated beneath a near starless sky, no moon, just darkness all around, from the water to the silhouette city backdrop to the roof of the world, I closed my eyes and opened them again and there was barely any change.

What happened next was that I thought I felt a small fish swim beneath my back and it gave me a surprise, feeling at first like a hand or someone's toe against my skin. But it was a fish, or similar, because then what happened is it propelled itself from my back to a loose wave in my swimming shorts, finding itself stuck between the slopes of my bottom and the fabric mesh of my pants. I quickly pulled my pants off in a panic, holding them with one hand while checking with the other hand for the fish to make sure it had moved on. Once I was sure my aquatic interloper was gone, I realised I was swimming naked in the complete sensory darkness of the ocean baths. Before putting my shorts back on I thought, why not just leave it a few minutes more, so I placed my shorts beneath my back so I could feel them there as I floated facing the sky, arms out like an aeroplane in some inversion of looking down on night pastures, mirrored. As you might expect, I checked for my pants only to realise they were no longer with me. They had floated off beyond my body. Oh heck is what I told my friend. Heck and bother, this is not what I was seeking on a Tuesday night.

I quickly ran through the available options in my mind. Everything was so dark, save a few street lights down the main street, that I may have been able to exit the pool, sans clothes, get my shirt from the basket on my bike and wrap it around my lower half, toga style, as I carefully rode through the more shadowed trajectories of the city until I reached home. As I envisaged this scenario I kept picturing my shirt dropping a sleeve down into the spokes of the bike wheel and either throwing me over the handlebars or else ripping the fabric away from my body, revealing my sin and then soon after being charged with public indecency. Meanwhile I kept passing my feet and hands through the water in some desperate hope that I would feel my pants, and after some endless stretch of exasperated seconds or minutes wouldn't you know, there they were, on the bottom of the baths just a few metres away from where they must have sunk down and drifted slightly south. Oh the relief. I have never been so happy to put pants on in my life, is what I told my friend. Dark pants on a dark body in total darkness. That's how much you miss Katita then, said my friend.

On this walk just after New Year we were prophetic with our thoughts about when, how and why the new batch of wars would commence. Shortly after our walk I published an essay that gave our reasoning, a formula almost, if such a thing were possible, linking the temporal distance between the end of a war and the first headlines of social decay now that the moral certainty of good and evil was evaporating, connecting anti-establishment manifestos such as those from the Destructivists and Vorticists and Stridentists and Cannibalists, through Bikyoto in Japan, Iraqi modernism, the négritude movement, Jindyworobak, Brazilian cyberfeminism and the economic freedom of women and gender diverse folk particularly in relation to their subjugation by a population of men looking for a new living god that looks even better than they do, and this is important, via a simultaneous equation whereby the self-hatred of men is in direct proportion to the messianic beauty of the manufactured god which, if you carry the two and divide by three, equals a shiny new epoch of genocide and war to inject meaning where a void once dwelled.

This is the formula that was published in the journal of Pre-Emptive War Calculus mere hours before the first live stream of falling missiles appeared alongside Nintendo trailers:

$$\frac{\sum M_i(\Delta t) \times \Delta F}{M(t)\downarrow}, H \propto G \rightarrow W$$

where:

Δt = years between armistice and first
headlines of decay

M_i = anti-establishment movements ($i = 1 \dots n$)

F = index of women's economic freedom

H = male self-hatred coefficient

G = messianic beauty of the manufactured god

which truth be told I was nervous about giving over for publication, because the last thing I wanted was to hand over the keys to totalitarianism without also making an argument for the role of finite land aka Indigenous rights and its relationship with virtual reality property development, and so on. There was so much more to take into account than I could fit into the article. But, with war only days away, my hand was forced.

While my friend and I developed the structure for these ideas on our walks beneath the gaze of mountain lean, the seeds from which they developed feet were first sealed and delivered in those letters back and forth between The Boxer and me, and even then I knew that the best of them came straight out of the radio in those backrooms of the rural pubs he sat in while embalming his hands in steady rhythms of tape, like a surgeon wrapping a wound, passing a figure eight of tape between thumb loop and palm, seemingly without any interest in the world outside his fists other than what I knew, only barely from his letters to me, that there was always a radio on a table beneath a window providing linear midday light, the radio always buzzing with bass resonance, detuned and out of range, broadcasting news.

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| [=====] |
/   ( ) VOL   TUNE ( )   \
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On the radio a voice discusses troop movements, air strikes and the possibility of a ceasefire. There is a description of drones that spool fibre optic cables and the scissors that disarm them, talk of satellite photos showing what is understood to be the scarred desert remains left by a tornado that travelled across a remote part of the outback some months ago, without anybody knowing at the time. The scar in the dirt is eleven kilometres long. Weather reports follow stock updates and racing odds. The Boxer straps one knuckle pad down, flexes his hand, tapes back around the wrist, clenches the fist, and then turns to the other hand. He produces no sound, just a shifting of light. The Boxer sat in these rooms in which other men of similar intention waited to injure and be injured, and where uncertain boys were posted by their fathers beside them to ask a question, to ask what they think their chances are out there, in the fight, to which The Boxer, like all the other men, speaking into the corners of the room, would say that the only thing that matters is learning how to be the loser.

Say when The Boxer opens the door of the bedroom provided to him on the second level of the pub that the courtesan he is travelling with is having a bath. He enters and peels off a fabric layer of sweat and blood and apocalypse and sits down on a sturdy timber chair in his green satin shorts with a white star sewn on. And say the courtesan he is travelling with, who he met six months prior and kept returning to, just to sit and listen to her talk, mostly, who is now travelling with him as they both have work out this way, beyond the borderlands, say she rouses from what must have been a very brief loss of awakesness whilst bathing. The Boxer can see that she has done here what has happened before, that she has retired to the bath late into the evening with lamplight reflecting against the aluminium-framed window that looks out onto the arctic rural crossroads, and she has tried to recline but uncomfortably so, and so she has placed, as she has done before, the paperback novel she was reading in the bath behind her head, nestled under the back of her neck. But then she became too comfortable and the book slipped from behind her and fell into the bath.

The courtesan, a name The Boxer has neither capitalised nor personalised because the bath has, both before and now, made all names provincial, knows that the paperback has slipped beneath the surface tension of the water. The pages stay down, soaked and heavy and blank, as all the letters of all the words have lifted from the paper and bob now on the bath water like an oily alphabet soup. Say The Boxer sees on the body of the courtesan all the words that he doesn't need, all the pronouns and pet names, the oral tics and verbal gestures never used, mirrored and displaced on her skin, all the reasons he never needs to say anything, only ever into the corners of the room if at all. When she lifts her knees up and they are tattooed with linguistic disjecta, as she shuffles her back up against the porcelain bend of the tub with the ruined leisure of some author's weekend draped across her breasts, vowels on nipples, consonants on her fingertips that hang and drop down this letter here and that dream of perpetuity there, and her right arm that by some miracle of sequenced liquidity reads five complete words in a fair row: Their Most August Public Organ.

I can see The Boxer loosening the tape wrapped around his hands in the reflection of this passenger two seats in front of me as they adjust the strap of their wristwatch. A billboard advertising either a prestigious school or funeral home or a way to recycle industrial waste or a new church with graffiti providing an alternative suggestion for what Jesus might do or an investment opportunity to obtain the last few blocks of land in a new housing estate or the radio frequency for the local emergency broadcasting service, is in view only long enough to be smudged into a parallax of silhouetted typeface cast through the train window and onto the pale skin of the woman sitting in front of the passenger with the wristwatch, intersecting with a tattoo of a sword or a crucifix within the parameters of her brown halter top. For my part, on my way to see my friend, further south of Newcastle now, I look out into the occasional fields and see one that I remember from this same time last year, or thereabouts. Just before New Year, after Christmas. There is a superstructure here that was not present before. A full sentence where none used to be.

The bitumen beneath each footfall was super-smooth, super-flat, a diorama of place collapsed in two dimensions. Process flattened, materials without reference to source, it was heavier than anything I could imagine. The bridge weighed more than the Earth and all its contents. Whether it was a bridge or not was a sudden consideration. It may have actually been a curving overpass as it leaned upwards from the ground on an uncoiling of pylons. Or, if it was bridge-like at the point it reached across the pastoral fields, it could not yet have been described as such given that its intentions were incomplete. That's the reason I stopped, of course. How could I pass up the opportunity to walk up this liminal expanse, so incongruous on a landscape I had passed window-side for a decade with its low-lying grazing fields, the cows that would gather in late afternoon in an unbroken constellation of black and white dots, like pinpricks in a map poked through from underneath, out to the endless horizon with only ontological incompleteness beyond where The Boxer and the courtesan were, say, entwined in twin voids. Ah, I really miss Katita.

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When it rained too much the grass out here turned oceanic and the livestock moved to the harbourside on thin risen boardwalks of mounted soil that gave passage to and from the schedule of their days. And now this, two point four billion dollars set aside to pull a roadway through the clouds. I know the figure because that's what the billboard said, yes I remember now, not a school or a religion or a waste facility, it was the promise of another lane, just one more lane, subject to viable reductions. Wait, viaduct, that's the word. This is a viaduct. I walked up along the middle dotted line of both lanes, one foot in the left and one in the southbound. At times like this, walking in this way, as the only possibly conscious man alive, I feel there exists within the atlas of my interior cartography some three distinct types of place.

There are places I can routinely go whenever I want. Then there are places I have been but will likely never return to. And, there are places that do not exist but which I nonetheless think about often. For example, I think about the streets and public parks through which I walk my dog of a morning and afternoon, or the cafés I frequent for lunch, that are all within easy, daily reach. Then, there are those places I spent a week on international work ventures, The Bund in Shanghai with the nests of telegraph wires hung on the corners of sandstone buildings, when I was completely lost and making my way from one side of the river to the other, somehow, through parks and laneways I will never again visit even if I tried, or the bulldozed Warre Village Theatre in Gauteng, or the volcanic crater that I swam in, there are photos on an SD card somewhere, somewhere near the crest of the Great Dividing Range, never since identified on any chart or satellite map. Then there are the places that do not exist, yet occupy such a broad and abundant regional span within me that they take equal measure against the rest.

Say when I travel on a train like this one and the carriage pauses at the Hawkesbury River Station, I think about meeting Katita there, she caught an earlier train and has been waiting beside the platform beneath a weeping willow reading a mathematics pamphlet, a light treatise about points on an elliptic curve and the relationship between falling autumn leaves and cryptography. We would make our way to a double-storey white weatherboard hotel with warm bedside lamps that make good on the promise made by the small windows and heavy blinds, because we would not be there to sleep. Not Katita and I. No. We would kneel on the floor and be deeply silent together. Now, this place does not exist, nor does the pebble courtyard out the back, with its orange tree and fallen fruit, and yet I think about them. I think about walking back to the station together the next day, and again she will depart first. The way I would remember her arms hanging down the sides of her thrift shop dress, the pressed fabric embrace recalled and still living in all the impossible places of my interiority. I hoped that they would never finish construction here.

Across a channel of water, diverted behind a white geodesic framework that might one day be used for an outdoor music venue, I see a windbreak of pines. Beyond is a clenched fist of oak trees nestled behind what looks very much like where Katita and I experienced our first instance of corrupted ROOT data. This in itself is not quite the right phrasing for what it was and is and will be. It was possibly the first, or the second, or the third instance depending on what degree of interference you count as corruption, or whether it was corruption at all depending on your vantage point, which I have learned to give a little bit of air to since Katita has gone off to explore her own take on this, while I'm here alone on the train on my way to see my friend. But I will keep to the original phrasing for what it's worth and say that in a grove not unlike the one back there, where I parked our truck against the hackneyed wooden fence rounding a field of scattered dustlight, in another of the inland sequence of golden fields pressed together into a tapestry of dry grass rising to distant hills, impossible to imagine any further reality behind this one, I noticed the first corruption.

Katita had strung a blanket, our bedding, between the forked branches of two oaks while I worked on the trunk of a third, checking on a ROOT module we had installed within a division of its heartwood, framed in bark, wired loosely across its diameter with twine to hold it in place. I made it a practice to check that the hardware was still ticking along after a night in the elements lest any moisture impact the screen and to confirm the solar had activated at sunrise. While Katita dried the blanket and sat cross-legged beneath, curating an archive of data for installation on the next leg of our trip, I ran the standard diagnostics and saw the seeds of what would come to change everything.

uploaded:

files: 214

bytes: 489220

checksum: 7ff3a

current:

files: 214

bytes: 489221

checksum: 7ff3a

The number of files was the same but there was the difference of a single byte between what Katita and I had uploaded yesterday and what was there this morning. This made no sense to me. When I told Katita I could tell she knew it was a little strange but also not worth concerning ourselves with while knowing that me being who I am would be unable to let it go until I found an answer so she gestured as if to say Leif just run the diagnostics and do what you need to do so you can move on. So I did just that. I plugged my computer into the ROOT module still embedded in the tree and put on my old EyePhone VR headset from the 90s, easier to use in the outdoor morning light than squinting into the screen of a laptop, and sought out the byte-sized discrepancy. There have been modifications made to the headset over the years, taped back together as plastic straps failed, but also ways to keep it safe from the weather since outdoor use was its primary function, much like the ROOT hardware. By now the VR headset looked like a stained glass cathedral that rain could safely glide down, warbling amniotic shine flutter in degrees. I fired it up and ran a script to locate the issue.

TRACE DELTA +1

/text/Kendall_BellBirds_1869.txt

UPLOADED:

It lives in the mountain

CURRENT:

It leaves in the mountain

DELTA:

+ a

CHECKSUM:

unchanged

There it was. Bell-Birds by Henry Kendall was one of the poems we often saved to modules, given its formative role in Australia's recent literary history. I typed it straight from the source, an Angus and Robertson 1991 edition of the book, my father's copy. What I couldn't get to grips with was how the line had changed or not since yesterday. It is the third line of the poem, where the bell-birds can be heard after the opening couplet, the channels of coolness and so on, we are given the source.

It lives in the mountain

and yet the version that now existed on this little printed circuit board nestled in the tree instead read:

It leaves in the mountain

I told Katita and she screwed up her nose and tipped her head in a way that in certain conditions would have me anthropomorphise her as a feline sensing an uncertain character of milk, but which I knew at this moment was a repeat of her earlier inclination. Leif, either leave it alone or find the answer and be done with it. She reclined back with her laptop on her knees. Rather than ask her to check the original source file for Bell-Birds I wrestled with the most confusing part of the whole thing, which is why the diagnostics said that yes, one byte had changed between the initial upload and the scan today, but that the checksum would report this as 'Unchanged'. This made no sense. It had changed, the word 'lives' had become 'leaves'. I had to go deeper, so I booted into my broader file repository.

In retrospect I should have looked for obvious signs. My own name, Leif, was not dissimilar to the shift from 'lives' to 'leaves'. Too, it is a neat anagram of Life. The tree was knocking on the door at the very front of my self and yet I was staring out the back window the whole time, trying to justify how change might not actually be change. During this data excursion, while searching for the original text file of Bell-Birds, I found adjacent folders and documents from the period when Katita and I first met. As per the diagnostic requirements on my modem, I inhabited the avatar I settled on during the early days when Katita and I would sit on SecondLife together. Floating down the wire, above the billy buttons, I tread into file updates above the city harbour, the low polygon watertable and unfocused sky as an adaptation of empty space.

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My party costume was accidentally coherent. The sunset revellers on the neighbouring rooftop called out scores as more folks from the Sans Courte apartment complex rose from the stairwell in fancy dress and grabbed a beer and had a number out of ten yelled across the divide. This was when Katita first approached me. Eight out of ten, she said, And yet I only scored a six. What the fuck. What even are you, a bushranger from space. I looked at my beard and flannel and jetpacks and crimes against the state and said How dare you. And are those goon bag jetpacks, she asked, and then, Is there any wine left in them, and I said Yes and did a shimmy to slosh them left and right. Katita of course was immaculately put together, wearing a shiny reflective skirt that poured lengths of cosmos down around her. I recall her singlet had a cylinder, a sphere and a pyramid sewn above text explaining how the shirt spoke volumes. She squeezed my left goon bag into a plastic cup while string theories of fairy lights imitated Katita's universe before it assumed form.

Someone walked past dressed like the Internet. We looked out at the ocean and saw coal ships sitting on the horizon like watch batteries on a thin shelf. They were waiting their turn to be welcomed into the harbour to power the city. Katita told me she studied mathematics and art and for some reason I said I was a boxer, and when she looked at me in that way I said Well, boxing history, and then Well I read a lot, but then I said Listen this might be a tangent, but I'd just found a box of old hacker manuals and was tinkering with a module that could hold a few kilobytes of data. I couldn't get it to speak to any other devices as part of a communicative daisy chain. Like these fairy lights, I pointed to the line of them above us, That's how it should work. Katita put her cup down, picked up a napkin and pulled a pen out of my beard, an action that will remain an ontological miracle forever unsolved. She popped the lid and drew:

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She said You don't need every node to speak to every other node, you just need enough routes so your message can survive losing one, Boxer.

The way Katita sat astride the parapet and listened to every score called out across the void while maintaining eye contact, how she dropped her eyes to my fists and said Tell me about boxing, and I said Well the most important thing, really the only thing that matters, is learning how to be the loser. That shouldn't be too hard then, Katita said as she jostled my jetpacks into a crumpled symmetry, smirking and saying, You could be a boxer one day, and then Tell me what your boxing name would be. Elias Shore, I said, but then immediately had to pull back on impersonating this man I had learned of in the suburban backyard shed of the historian my father and mother used to assist with the gardening. I explained to Katita who he was, how his Indigenous heritage had to be masked as Cuban. Was that his birth name, she asked, always knowing the right thing to ask, listening as she always was across the void, and I said Well it all depends on who you ask. The posters said Eli Shore, newspapers Ellis Shaw, promoters sold him as Elías del Puerto. None of these were the name he was born with, though. That was a name written in faint script on the bottom of a certificate I found in the old garage.

Because the historian wrote in his shed, on milk crates, and left his papers there when my parents brought the mower out, and because I was polite and just sat and looked around and read a little, he left his notes on his paint flecked workbench, beside a clamp, beneath a heavy hand plane, that I read like I read everything there. I told Katita that while I know the name he was given by his family, which is not Elias or Ellis or Eli or Shore or Shaw or any other variation, I will not say it. The reason I will not say it, I continued, without her asking, is that there is no database, online or in microfiche or library stacks, that holds his name. It only existed in that faint script which was an original, primary source, long since taken to the dump with all the other possessions of the local historian, likewise once in the long extinguished mind of the same, but not in the paperback he'd written, and nowhere else I have ever seen except in my own head. I will protect it, I told Katita. You will fight for it, Katita said, You will fight to keep it out of circulation, and yet you have already told me too much. Quickly tell me something else, she said, Your name, Boxer, so I forget all about whatever it is you've not told me. You can make that up too, to upload your belief.

Twenty three taps on the skin, like morse code. Prime, I tell Katita in the dark. We've been sitting in the dirt courtyard of an anonymous country ever since the sun was rotated against, the fire in the barrel reduced to ashen splinters while the stars play act as embers on the roof. Good, Katita says. She begins tapping again, using her biro, against my bicep. I count fifty seven and wonder if I'm going to end up with ink poisoning, like how if you chew too many apple seeds you get cyanide. My arm has as many blue dots as the sky has tiny fiery holes. I ask Katita if she can remember whether the ROOT module we installed down by the river has Bell-Birds on it and she says Quit stalling. Just go with your gut, if you think I tapped fifty seven times. So now I need to question whether I've counted correctly and whether the number is a prime or not. I say No it is not a prime and Katita says Lucky guess Grothendieck and then kisses me on the cheek. I do not wash off the ink from my arm in the river the next morning and as I tap out fifty seven finger jabs into the window of the train here, all these years on, I remember how I thought Katita was being salacious by asking me about growth and dick.

In the bedroom of our apartment on King Street, sitting back to back in front of the louvre windows that face our favourite pub, I tap out another sequence of primes Katita has taught me onto the keyboard as we log onto a simulation made by a university student, they shared it on the local BBS. She in her radiating holographic skirt, me in full jetpack bushranger mode, our avatars explore a generative landscape that visualises what Newcastle will look like in the future. You can set it to advance ten years forward, one hundred years, one thousand. We take it all the way, the year three thousand-ish, roaming where vines allow access.

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Katita is all scientist. Why haven't trees wrapped limbs around that hotel yet they have that church. I am too literal. The bus terminal is too westward. We both agree that a thousand years of deferred maintenance has significantly improved the CBD.

Flying over the city, admiring where grass between the flagstones in the mall had become the dream of a neo-bushland, I don't know if it was Katita or whether it was me who first heard the bird call. The game had otherwise been absent of sound other than a wash of ambient noise, but it rang out like a repeating bell. MIDI by the tone of it, not a sound recording, yet the intention is clear. Katita recognised it straight away as a bell miner, like an electric piano tuned to a high octave, staccato tapped. I wasn't sure, bellbirds are gully birds, why here in Newcastle, even given the thousand year gap. How accurate can a MIDI file even be, is a wrong-sounding bellbird still a bellbird, and other questions of mine that didn't need an answer. Later I extract the sound file and use it in our first proper ROOT module experiment. Using an empty ice cream container for the hardware to be seated within, tied to the trunk of a willow in our yard, I set a trigger to our kitchen clock's sync pulse to establish a basic communication protocol to tell the module when to start its bellbird rendition. Katita and I leaned against the sink with our dessert bowls, looking into the yard. And then it began to sing.

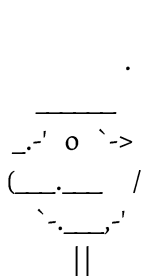
Before we were in the middle of everything, while Katita sat war dialling paddocks in my ute, I looked through outdated maps we'd picked up in service stations on the road. UBD-Gregory's street directories, Caltex road maps, unfolded to twenty-times the size of the windscreen. When the opportunity presented itself, to either take the objectively real turnoff down a physical lane, or instead to follow the map and drive down a road that hasn't existed for twenty years, we always followed the map. Sometimes Katita would reach what sounded like a modem, but the handshake would fall apart like a desiccation of insect wing scatter. We read bulletin boards in bakeries, honour shields of duxes and sporting heroes in timber laden community halls, racing guides, menus written in hand, hotel guest books, radio logs. Katita photographed a payphone in the main street of a two pub town and I memorised the ten digits stamped on its side. Unwrapping a cold sausage roll, I turned to Katita's wide full toothed grin as she made complete connection with a phone system the next district over, like finding money in a coat pocket. I kissed her cheek and we drove long throughout the night.

Not far south of a broken bridge we may have worsened when we tried to take the truck over, Katita prises our soap from its caddy as we shift our weight down an embankment to the flats beside a river. We performed this ballet routine a half dozen times a week, hanging our clothes on reeds and saplings, bracing for the chill and cleansing relief of the waters. I would wash Katita's long hair, would project new cosmologies on the half moon separations that pastoral tanning applied to her fair skin, hum new odes into the genesis myth that we were the only man and woman on this empty planet. When the soap slipped away, down river, we both held a salute and thanked it for its service. Depending on the current, we would often lie on our backs and allow the river to carry us too, before we doggy paddled to our starting point. We did this again and again, sometimes while we held hands, like synchronised swimmers, other times in counterpoint to one another, as Katita would slip past me as I waded back against the flow. When the first mosquito took blood we would take our revenge and then call it quits, and whatever one of us was saying at the time would be replaced by splashing water.

With, by now, many hundreds of nodes installed across the valleys and golden outfields of zones spanning a solid half decade of work, there was a night we sat in the ute and listened to the radio, to slide guitar fused with treble talk and requests for more sorrow, please, while I ran diagnostics on the fifty closest modules and Katita finished off a can of chilli con carne and kept time with the music by flipping her thermos lid down on a known wobbly offbeat, when the modules began to stream data of incoming rain. It started on the other side of the plains and gave us no indication of its presence other than the numbers that fed into my monitor. Humidity sensors, yes, but other data points too that seemed out of reach for what the hardware should detect. Katita leant over and put her face into the numbers. I say, she said, Nine minutes. Using her thermos lid to keep time with the rainfall, now, we hear the quietening of wildlife and the increased fuzz of AM frequencies as we watch one node talk to another node to another node all the way down to us, as the rain can be seen as a wafting veil of static on the horizon, like a bride falling in and out of memory. As it hits the bonnet, Katita says it's forty seconds late.

Big rain is everywhere, replacing all sensory data with sheets of infinite abundance, all noise and all pressure. We don't try to speak. I remember looking through the grid of ROOT modules as they recorded the weather and I made estimations as to what was giving voice to the numbers. One of the modules went dark and I point it out to Katita. She mouths Ridge East, and I nod. We installed it within the fold of a willow tree on a peak looking out across a network of tennis courts that looked to have been out of use since last century. Moisture, I think, or perhaps the wind has dislodged it. We can drive back up there tomorrow. When it comes back online I look at Katita and she just shrugs, but when I click into its readings to check its status, she leans in and realises what I do. It recorded data on the rainfall during its outage, which seems obvious, there must have just been a network outage. But the thing is, the data doesn't even come close to what the other nodes recorded. It reads like a different language. Katita would later say it observed the storm more accurately than any of the others. It's like the module went to sleep, had a dream about the rain, and then told us all about it when it woke.

The original anomaly of the world is that there is a surplus of truth. Temporal palimpsest, a diachronic sublime. Seeing the present and imagining it replicated time and again in the past and the future, in slightly different clothes. Anemoia, anticipatory nostalgia, chronothesia. What is happening today is what has always been. Leif, keep the elbow in when you carry anything heavy, it's all the same movement. It's a shifting of weight like it's a shifting of light, like two thoughts at once that you need to give attention to. Knees slightly bent, light on the ball as you drop to the heel and pivot east and then west and back and repeat east on a hop like a hi hat paradiddle. I suppose you're sleeping on the couch of such and such, all that warmth and gentle appraisal of line and intention in the other room, the spaces you wish to inhabit as you necklace the void. I'm leaving Walcha in the next day or two, I've been offered a fight out further west, further north. It sounds like what you've been reading lately has been giving you a sense of what comes next. I have a feeling we'll cross paths one day soon, not literally but, you know. Keep it up. The Boxer.



-----++----- It is while Katita is rinsing a bowl or folding a blanket that she begins to recite the poem. There are bellbirds in the glen beyond the pastoral radiance that is the late evening sundrop and she begins just fine but then gets to the line about how the *dripping rocks gleam* and she says *the leafy pools glisten*. I said, You mean *the leafy pools listen* and she says Well that's a nice turn of phrase but Henry Kendall wrote *glisten*. I can't believe what I'm hearing, I say Sweetheart, let's check the text, and I'm thinking come on, it's all about how the leafy pools are listening to the silver-voiced bellbirds, nature is receptive to the call of these notes and echoes. When I open the directory of the ROOT module in the truck and scroll through to the third stanza, of this poem that has been saved countless times across these edgelands, what I read is beyond all reasoning.

*Where dripping rocks gleam and the leafy pools glisten*

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I get my phone out and search for the poem and find myself somewhere called Welcome to the homepage of Perry Middlemiss where the poem is visible in font family monospace and there on the twentieth line is the same mistake:

*Where dripping rocks gleam and the leafy pools glisten*

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We typed out the poem into the ROOT module from an old Angus and Robertson edition of the book, a nineteen ninety one pressing of The Poems of Henry Kendall. That edition was not with us in the truck or our field bags, but in a taped up cardboard box in a storage container on Industrial Drive, Mayfield, some two or three hundred kilometres away. Years later when I opened the storage container and went through the books, I rummaged anxiously until I found the book and then took great care not to open it or allow it to spontaneously fall open in front of me in any capacity. Something else I learned years later is that Schrödinger never came up with the cat in the box analogy as a way of explaining his own theory, but rather as a dismissal of Heisenberg's structural ontology.

Some months later, I'm attending an exhibition of early Australian fairy tales at the University of Sydney, in part, I'm actually attending a work conference on a completely different field and topic but I make my way to the fairy tales and see the works of Ida Rentoul Outhwaite and all those moth-winged elves and pixies imported from European fantasies into a land of already plentiful myths hewn to the blood in the sand, when I nearly gave myself whiplash trying to turn away from an illustrated page of, who else, Henry Kendall and those cursed Bell-Birds, and what do you think I saw beside the watercolour magenta parabolas of dappled glade but those lines my eyes could not avoid capturing word after sequenced word until the dripping rocks gleamed and yes, the leafy pools - wait for it - *listened*. They *listened*, in this nineteen twenty three dated typewritten hand illustrated piece of firm card leaning against adjustable plastic shelving. I took out my phone to take a photo and later, when I looked back at it, could see only the reflection of down lights masking any opportunity to read the word again, another gag from the cosmic jester. But that hardly mattered. Katita recited what the system knew.

I think the PA is asking my questions for me, but they are stations: Wyong, Wyee, local Indigenous names for, I think, places of running water, of bush fire, of words and worlds that exist on the other side of every iteration of time I will ever become associated with. I catch Warnervale and the voice breaks up, though it continues for several seconds. Outside, a sign gives the name in full, followed by a bench and the end of the platform. There is a rattle beneath the window and I put my elbow on the ledge, which stops it until I shift my arm. The seat is warm against my back and I am looking forward to soon seeing my friend. Our meeting place must be only a few stations south, and then a little walk. There is a fence close beside the rail here and beyond the fence a little yard with three chairs stacked against a shed, the door open, a length of blue hose running out from it, and by the time I have followed the hose to where it disappears into grass the yard has gone and there is the brick wall of an old Mechanics' Institute. A road comes up from below and behind. I can see over a sidelong hedge into the empty front seat of a van, and then the road leans away and the hedge continues in parallax.

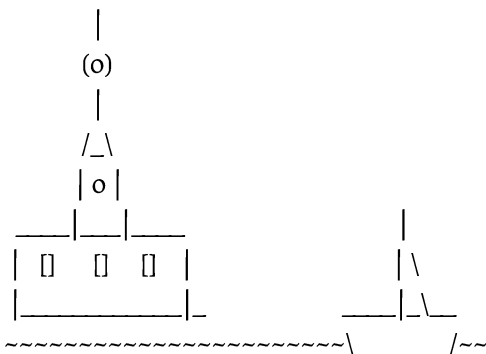
Not long after the glisten / listen incident I was finishing a maintenance log, matching our handwritten record of what had passed in and out of the modules against the printed ROOT export, when I found a line for which there was no corresponding entry in the book. I put my finger beneath it and looked again. There was a transmission at three forty in the morning and another at three fifty-two. Neither of us was ever working at those times. I must have copied a time into the wrong column or left something switched on through the night, and I am annoyed at how much checking will be required to clarify something of no importance to anybody but me. While I check the clocks and the stored times, Katita leans in, hair all amok in sundown, and asks whether I am nearly finished. She turns the paper towards the remaining light and runs her finger across the line rather than down it, which is something I had not thought to do because I was looking for a mistake in the schedule. Then she gives a little laugh. This one sends it there, she says, and here, look, this one sends something back. Her finger stays on the page until I have followed it. I cannot move my body.

Katita takes the pencil from beside my hand and circles the two entries. I look at the geostamp. The road to the receiving tree is an hour north. I'm eager to get there and get some sleep before an alarm wakes me for a three thirty debug. Of course I don't sleep, and neither does Katita. At three forty a filename blinks into being. Neither of us has touched anything. We wait for the rest of the file to arrive. It takes so long I think it must have timed out or been an error, but then it finishes. It is an audio file. When I plug headphones into the module and pass an ear bud to Katita, we both immediately know what it is. Months before, behind a bakery in a town with little else between the road leading in and the one leading out, we set a microphone on a picnic table and recorded a butcherbird singing a little song. At three fifty-two, the module sends a file back to the tree that sent us the first. The filename is the same, and so is the size. I open the outgoing copy while Katita still has the other ear bud. We listen for several seconds before I start it again. When I reach to stop it, Katita puts her hand on mine and asks to keep listening. We both know. This is the same recording, running backwards.

I remember us looking for somewhere to pull up out of the midday sun when we come upon a thing. For several kilometres I have been calling it a silo, although as we approach I find myself having to account for more and more of it. It is cream along the top and green underneath, swollen at one end and drawn out at the other into a blunt projection with a row of openings along its side. It has something of a handle, although the handle is filled with sky and large enough to hoop our truck. Katita says it is a seed. A plaque supplies the names of a president, a secretary, a treasurer and the members of a committee. Beneath these are the businesses that contributed materials. The concrete has the small exposed stones of old public swimming pools. Katita wants me to take a photograph in which she appears to be giving birth to this big thing. I crouch beside the truck and direct her, and she is laughing and telling me to instead move myself, which improves the photograph immediately. Back on the road, Katita rests one foot on my knee while she takes a grass seed out of her sock. The thing remains visible for a long time, then the road turns and there is only the stubble of one harvested paddock after another.

During that earlier Summer of fifty-cent Australian paperbacks (later of paperbarks, now of paperarcs) in which my correspondence with The Boxer found its feet, I stay for a while with a woman whose couch has a low place by a front window that overlooks an old arcade. I read a book in which somebody has been expected home for several pages, and whenever a car slows outside I look up on their behalf. Before anything further happens in the plot, I am asked to move my things as the woman I am staying with walks in a little too purposefully holding scissors. A friend is coming to have her hair cut. I ask if this is something she knows how to do, but she's already shuffling me out of the way to place a towel down. 8< -----  
The friend enters, I feel like I know her, I may even have been her lover for a while. She was introduced to me some months ago by someone who was not quite a friend but who came upon me like a character from a book, pulling up in a car and walking up to and past me. I move to the back stoop. I can hear the two women inside, although it sounds like many more, laughing in rooms full of sunlight. I will return to this afternoon, as now, for stretched decades.

One evening when we are parked beneath what in the morning will reveal themselves as a grove of some of the largest trees I've seen outside of a school textbook, Katita logs on to an old reconstruction of Newcastle still running. She sends me the IP address. I arrive beside the harbour wearing my trusty jetpack and beard and she is already waiting there in her classic holographic skirt, default character templates now and forever. The city looks as though composed by modelled renders of old photographs, caramelised and half-melted but still retaining enough headroom to navigate the streets unfettered. Katita asks me to do a voice, to take her on the cyber bushranger heritage tour of Newcastle. I ask her to remain with the group and allow sufficient room for members of the public to pass. There is nobody else on the footpath. She moves closer. At Customs House I tell her about the ball above the clock tower, how it dropped at one so the ships could set their clocks. I gesture to it, this spherical box catching afternoon digital dynamic light, ambient occlusions, chromatic aberrations of emissive materials, volumetric cookies of dust that buffer all day.



Katita stops outside the Victoria Theatre and asks if this can be part of the tour. We pass through the entrance into a dimness furnished with brass rails and red upholstery, and she immediately begins looking for the stairs to get up to the mezzanine, but they either haven't loaded in or whoever built this simulation didn't get to them yet or whatever. I look at Katita's screen to make sure my body is holding hers and I jetpack us both up above the stage. She asks if we can go higher, right up to the ceiling. I try to navigate the vertical ascent, tentative like an angel in training, and I find myself placing my foot on the brake of the truck out of caution. We clip our heads through the roof ever so slightly, and see there is yet another theatre stage, just like the pallor window of a train, even further up.

Say The Boxer is sitting on the edge of the bed in yesterday's green satin shorts, with one foot on the bed and the other resting on the cold boards. Morning is through the leadlight. The courtesan is dressed except for her shoes. There are days that I can furnish for them more readily than I can remember my own. She needs the bed to finish packing, so he hauls himself up and reorients his bruises. He buttons his shirt from the bottom, where he can see what his swollen fingers are attempting until she comes over and finishes him off. She asks him where it hurts and he shrugs and she looks at the sun and he nods to himself and knows she won't be with him tonight. Someone else is expecting her in the next town over and she'd like to arrive with time to eat and wash beforehand. Too, there's a bookshop there she wants to visit to replace the ruined paperback wrapped in a towel on the vanity. She folds stockings into her overnight bag and packs away two disposable caps for the shower that the hotel gives guests along with wrapped soap. You know, she says, you can wear these caps on your feet when the showers have that sheen of bacteria and grime. Plus they're fun to slide around on, slalom style.

The purse from last night has been counted twice and spread across the bed. They settled on a sum for the travelling days before leaving the city. They agree that she will drive as far as the bookshop. He can rest beside her, and they will buy something to eat before leaving rather than stop for a meal on the way. She stands between his knees to straighten his collar and stays there. He puts a hand against the small of her back and it feels like sound, the fade-out to a song before the radio broadcast brings up the volume on the next transmission. She moves her cold hands inside his shirt, undoing the good work from earlier, and he makes a noise that surprises them both. Her hands stay there until they are warm, and then a little longer because he has begun stroking the back of her neck. When they are out of town she begins telling him the part of the book she had reached. He listens with one hand holding two sandwiches steady between them. She says the protagonist had just started to talk about their most august public organ and I see her driving with her coat open and The Boxer looks like a man who isn't a great listener because he likes the quiet, or at least has grown accustomed to it.

On one of our maintenance rounds Katita asks me to bring the towel from behind the seat. We spread it beneath the tree and put the tools along one edge. There is a module whose casing has begun to separate from the tree. The bottom screws turn without coming out and there are ants beneath the bracket. At the back, a split in the plastic lies against an old wound in the trunk and a run of resin has come down behind the housing and entered where the halves no longer meet. It has gathered on the board, coagulating into densities of translucence. Where pieces of circuit board have cracked and feathered, the resin has fused new connections in spindles of gluey cord like soft pine needles. I wonder whether, even given the damage, it might still power up. A piece breaks free no larger than the end of my thumb, which shuts down that train of thought. Katita holds it towards the sun and moves her thumb away from the clearer edge. I ask what she can see. Back in the truck she places it beneath the windscreen and it rides with us on the dashboard. Katita has turned it sidelong so a little copper track in the resin gives the impression of data swimming into amber light.

Some days later Katita is haphazardly spinning the piece of amber between her fingers as she leans on the steering wheel with her notebook, reviewing civic records we'd been cataloguing for future entry. At a point I have never been able to determine, Katita surpassed my predilection for local history with a fervour I had not seen coming. On my computer I opened a list of digitised files waiting to be copied across to a future module, some local boxing records I found in a box behind a foreclosed gymnasium and then scanned for later addition to the archive. Katita has found that the man who took admission at the fights later kept the municipal pool. I follow one of the links out of the preview and into the record already on the module and do a search for Elias Shore, or any of his misnomers, whose fights should help us place the dates. I open dir/ROOT/Hunter/boxing/

-----OO\_041-----

SHORE, Elias

4 DEC 1954 10 rounds

result won on points

source scan\_014.tif

history hunter\_north.txt

/next\_page

-----

I keep scrolling down to see where the scans might be appended to an existing folder of related fight records. On the following page there are, as expected from the links made across datasets, the alternative names given to Elias across his bouts.

-----OO\_O42-----

ELIAS SHORE

also recorded as:

Eli Shore -----> Fights

Ellis Shaw-----> Fights

Elías del Puerto ---> Fights

-----

There is another name beneath these. It is the name his family gave him, the one I wouldn't say aloud to Katita that night on the rooftop lest it escape the closed system of the faint script written on the bottom of the certificate since taken to the tip. Until now the name only survived in my memory. The name, his family name, is printed on the screen in the same type as the hall and weight at which he fought. I have never typed it. Whenever I have remembered it, I have done so without moving my mouth. And it is this that is the crucible of everything, this whole damn thing, from then till now through the window of this carriage, when it all becomes too much for me, beyond every fiction.

The unchanged checksum with it lives / leaves in the mountain; when the storm rolled in and the modules gained atmospheric premonition and differentiated variance; Bell-Birds again, damn you Henry Kendall, with listen / glisten; the transmissions neither Katita nor I initiated, the recording of the butcherbird sent forwards and backwards as in some automated sequence of call-and-response, a conversation between machines for their own pleasure, not for ours. While it is true that I have often been afraid of forgetting the name that Elias Shore's family gave him, for reasons I hesitate to be too explicit about even now, and while I frequently brought it to mind while waiting for a page to load, for a module to come alive, or in the dark while Katita was tapping prime numbers against my body and later when she was asleep, I always took care to never say it even quietly, and to never, ever write it down. But now the work of remembering seems to have been performed for a reader I never intended. This private language was now part of the network. Fumbling through my papers, I already know I didn't put it there, and Katita didn't either. No. The name was birthed online of its own making.

There is a letter to The Boxer folded inside my notebook. I had left him in a car holding lunch and I had some inkling of the next pub he would be stopping at down the road. While Katita plays with the piece of amber and reads from her folder I take the letter around to the back of the truck and set it on fire. I do not write to The Boxer again. When I return to my seat Katita asks if the blankets are dry, our bedding from the night that got damp with morning dew. She had strung them over the branch of the tree we had wired the next module up to, waiting for it to power on while we kicked our feet into a cloud island of daisies and ate store-bought sandwiches. I look at her face as though trying to interpret an impossible number and then grab for my computer still interfacing with the ROOT module, scrolling back up past Elias Shore to the folder of pending documents still unverified and see what I had passed over with zero recognition just minutes before truth crashed.

-----OO\_O36-----  
/unverified/Blankets\_Drying.tmp  
-----

I turn the screen so she can see it. She reads the name, looks towards the file, then the line outside, and rests her hand, forever, on the back of my seat.

I ask Katita to come away with me, to leave. When I think back to the variations this scene could have taken on I sometimes have her say to me do you mean leave or leaf or life or live or Leif but what she actually does is shake her head in this sad way. She says she wants to continue. The blankets are still drying. I just sit there and want to take a hammer to every module we ever installed into every tree that never asked to be part of any of this. We can go off grid, I say I need to go off grid even when I know this is what the whole ROOT project was for, to create a post-truth empire of dust across a nation of collapsing grids, but look at us go, we went and made another one, or at least let a system create a dream of itself. Katita looks as serious as she can muster and says she wants to go on with the work. She says we need to do this together, this is only the beginning of whatever follows. And yet. And the truck stays with Katita. Most of what she needs is already fitted to it, and what I need can be reduced to a small bag if I lean on it while zipping it shut. She kisses me with enough intention that I just want to turn into static and detune the history of every idea my stupid head has ever conjured.

The voice disappears first. For a moment I continue hearing where it has been, the grain of it laid over the tune. A bell enters at the far end of a held note. By the time I locate the source there is another bell within it, like a light bulb in a skylight. The announcement starts again while I am looking at the window with my eyes closed, but it is cut off by muzak that distorts the signal and is pushed out of the carriage speaker by the voice trying to wrestle a pop orchestra of show tunes into submission. I am reminded of a similar piece of sonic dramedy in the foyer of a little hotel I stayed at near the ocean some eighteen months ago, a little brown speaker with lattice nested on its front, as the woman who ran the establishment kept accidentally turning on the radio while she held the button down to announce how long it would be until the kitchen closed. I arrive too late, but she could do eggs if I am prepared to have them as they come. Her husband says my motorbike can fit beside the bins in the yard. I go inland and then towards the coast and inland again, making a route out of available beds and dining rooms. Some I leave early. In others I stay another night without doing anything that requires it, except that I have not finished with the balcony, or I need to watch as the light moves across the ceiling for a while longer.

A man at the bar says I will be on my own upstairs and gives me a room key and one for the front door. I have paid for one bed and am being trusted with the building. Or, there is nobody at reception and a note asks me to ring a number, and while I wait for an answer a telephone on the desk starts ringing in front of me, which I pick up to book myself in. After dark I take a bath in a room large enough to dress a wedding party. When I pull the plug, the water can be heard moving through the hotel beneath me. I walk unadorned by fabrics throughout the wallpapered hallways, the empty function rooms, the rooftop with its parapets that I lean on while nursing a tumbler of water, looking at how the nation starts and finishes at the hotel's back fence, pastures the colour of absence, hearing the wind before it rises. On occasion I wake in the middle of the night and find a billiard table beneath a fitted cover in a room with curtains that were hung before Federation. I bounce balls off of the cushions and pretend I am one of the great snooker players giving an audience of ghosts a rare treat, witnessing trick shots of a variety never before performed in this hotel, otherwise silent amidst the hay and gravel and stars and no voices, not a word as one ball pads and then clicks another.

From the road I can see the Darling through a gap in the trees and, above it, the motel's open window. I turn in and skip up chalks of dust as I brake. Nobody has come for the due notices at reception. The pigeons have raised a new generation of squabs who now walk the hallways and tend to all raised surfaces. I sleep with my jacket over me and put it on again in the morning. The oil drum stands among tins on the gravel below. I climb onto the sill and move my hands from the gutter to the bricks under the tiles. There is a pause halfway up while I persuade my knee to try the arrangement again. All those years of couch surfing and shadow boxing, of leaning over paperbacks and circuit boards, where was the physio to prepare me for my forties. On the roof I take my phone out and connect to the old distributor, expecting nothing, yet there it is, a line like the horizon beneath a sun in backwards bloom. Beneath a Morse sequence of dashes there is a file that appears. I shadow the screen with my other palm, the one not cradling this dream of other days. The file directs, upon connection, to a folder, ROOT. Incredible, it still loads after all these years. There are documents that, of course, I did not add. There is a request for a photograph. Nothing surprises me. I scroll down, taking care not to close the directory.

-----  
/ROOT  
index.html  
README.txt  
/audio  
River\_NSW\_1500hrs\_Late20thCent.mp3  
AlfredHill\_StringQuartet5\_Allegro.mp3  
/text  
TomMaguire\_Extracts.txt  
Impressionism\_BushStudies.txt  
Graves\_TimeAndDirection\_1952\_Notes.txt  
/images  
Photo\_ServiceStation\_Dusk\_NSW\_1993.jpg  
Photo\_MotelFan\_Shadow\_1987.jpg  
Plate\_EucalyptusLeaf\_Study\_BW.png  
Spectrogram\_RiverAnomaly.png  
/unverified  
Their\_Most\_August\_Public\_Organ.txt  
Leave\_The\_Hinge\_Where\_It\_Is.tmp

-----OO\_O51-----

Request: Photograph of hall before ramp

-----  
A temporary file asks me to leave the hinge, I think I recall seeing one holding a manhole open above the reception area, where pigeons were coming and going. The heavens are open.

Say the courtesan arrives with several hours before her appointment and finds a public clock with an irregular shudder, as though each second has to be individually persuaded, like time is truth and truth is a woman. The town is still at lunch which is to say that every store is both open and closed, not out of business, yet, but vacant, in a state of empty rest. For a moment she stands beside the town's drinking fountain, holding the front of her dress against her chest while she closes her eyes and takes a sip from the parabola. Now she looks again, say, and there are a couple of shops open. She has a pie on a bench outside a bakery, lifting the pastry lid to let it cool. Two stores along, next to the Choo Chew Take Away, there is a bookstore. In the front window there are local history books about the region here, a book of poetry by the publican of the hotel where she might stay tomorrow, depending on events. Rather than replace the book lost to the bathwater she takes a different book bound in green cloth which has faded along the spine to the colour of a boiled pea. Inside, the paper is thick and pleasant to turn. She reads it on her way down the street, finishing the paragraph as she reaches the door. Once inside, she moves beyond what is knowable.

It is plain text, no author field. Ninety something kilobytes, which on this connection is the better part of an hour. I have nowhere to be. I'll sleep in the room again tonight. There is a blank interval after I open the title-file. I look across the yard at the ever-shifting light. My mouth moves ahead of the line and I stop in frustration, cranky that I already know not only the clause but the voice that wrote it. It is not my own. These are sentences I have already heard, a thousand times over, partway between memory and daydream, like a relief of sonic residue that hangs in the mind, inverted, some audible wavelength cave burrowed from the inside of the head outward. Before reading further I return to the request. I close my eyes and scroll through photos I have taken over the years and remember one. There is a hall, weatherboard, four steps and a boot scraper, Katita's elbow at the edge of the frame. A tennis court resides next door. I do not know if it is the hall anyone meant. It says Bunyah on the side. The file finishes transferring to the folder of unverified assets and I clip back to read the remains of Their\_Most\_August\_Public\_Organ.txt and get to the part where Katita is in the ocean baths and loses her swimmers before I shut down.

The foothold is harder to locate on the way down. I lower one shoe until it finds the bricks, then keep it still while the other foot and both hands make their separate arrangements. On the way out through reception I look up at the manhole. The hinge is holding and I leave it where it is. I cannot think of a reason I would ever have to make the effort to take it, but now I'm tempted to do so just to show that I don't take directions from lines of text on a monocolour display. That wouldn't be fair to the pigeons, though, or the tree that seems to be growing vines from the ceiling cavity out through the manhole. Outside, I stand beside the oil drum and recognise our dinner in what is left of its tins. I remember her crouching beside the drum in the last of the light. She turns the pot so the handle points towards us, then sits back on her heels to wait. The radio was playing, and she is certain about the singer but I know she's not right. When the announcer is about to reveal the answer Katita reaches over and turns it off. It's all just a lot of buzzing, she says. Let's just enjoy the sound of the sky rubbing against the solar system. She gets up to dance, knees slightly bent, drops to the heel, pivots east, south, and then we go inside for sideways music.

There is a pale print on the window where my forehead has been. Through it I can see a fence and a row of birds, their outcast wings repeating a silhouette of telegraph poles at slightly different angles, providing semaphore.

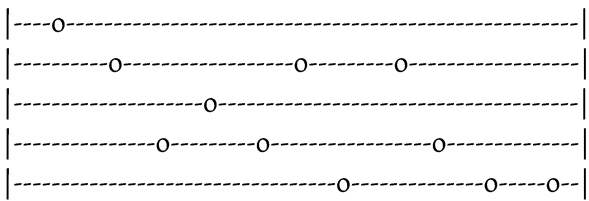
```

      /      \      \|      /
    o        o    --o    o    o    o
    /        /      \      |    / \
-----"-----"-----"-----"-----"-----

```

The train slows beside a platform. This is not where I am getting off. I am on my way to see my friend. Two seats ahead, a shoulder settles. The passenger's posture is familiar even before I look at them properly. I keep repeating a refrain and then I lift my bag onto my knees, then put it down again. This is not my station. The passenger two seats ahead heaves themselves up and adjusts the strap of their wristwatch, bandage-like. They are holding a bag just like mine. As the only person alive at the centre of the world, I watch them leave and the train speeds up again. I try to remember whether there was a sentence after the one I remember, after this one. Into the backyards of the town beside the train I see flakes of risen concrete and succulents in worn terracotta pots.

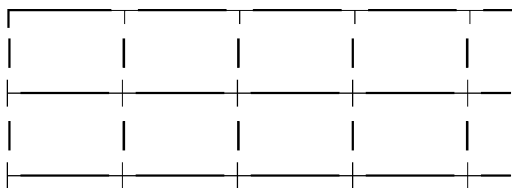
I have stopped humming without stopping the movement of my fingers. The carriage slows again and a loose part of the window plays a sequence of descending bass notes, like walking down into a basement, whenever we cross a join, and now I cannot separate it from what I have been tappppppping, this elongated drift to the ostinato



or maybe not a basement but a lower part of a field, a declivity of meadow where you might sit and watch the evening star dust off the learnings of the underworld on its return journey. I might sit in this pastoral dip and service my jetpack, ensure the fuel tank is aligned, the nitrogen regulator is distributing to the rocket nozzle, the catalyst bed is tight against the belly strap. Next to me would be a skirt, a flat mirrorball of circulating prisms, crystalline starfields, perhaps I use it as a thermal blanket as the dew settles in the morning. Before reading Come in Spinner on the beach one Summer, I thought the spinner was a World War Two fighter plane coming in to land.

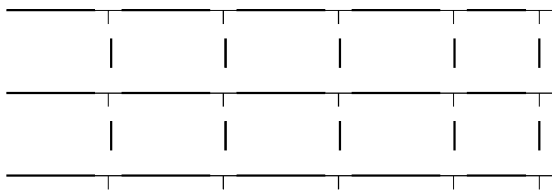
Only once did someone recognise me, at a motel run by a family, kids in the kitchen, cousins cleaning the hallways sort of setup. The grandfather leaned in, while I was in the dining room one evening, pretending to read while playing with the paper doilies, and said to me I know you, You're the guy who used to run around sticking boxes into trees with that girl, I saw you in my neighbour's field, he was none too pleased. I just looked blankly and said something to the effect of that being a long time ago with a mumbled apology. He sat down and said My nephew is into electronics, he said that new boxes have been going up, but they're different now. He looks me in the eyes and says Is this your operation, and I said No, I know nothing about it. With a terse finger he points towards a broad southern window, Two kilometres down the road, if it is yours, take it down. I finish my egg and corned beef brisket and return to my book. Other than my body, a bowl of fruit, a cabinet full of VHS tapes, a game of Othello, a water dispenser, an elaborately carved mirror, seven wicker backed dining chairs, a table and a lamp, the room is empty. I hold that visual of the old man's finger, like some cragged twig, and knock my knuckles on the doilies, counting primes.

Love is not enough light in the quiet corners of the room you don't have a key to. Love is the word we give to being wrong about our capacity for solitude. Love is a muscle memory associated with huddling, with shelter from failing gravity as buses and bus stations float upward, as bricks dissipate, rocket-fall winds backwards, as music is brought back to heartbeat and murmur as love allows you to hear outside the barrier, the blood. Love is a network that supplies its own meaning.



The following morning I drove to where the new variation of module had been installed, one of many I had seen in the intervening years, like lodestars, although when I said this word in my head I said nodestars, like nodestars guiding me across a scale map of all my past interiorities, pinballing between motels and service stations. As I fill up my bike I think back to the module, seen only from a distance, and imagine opening it up and finding a nest of wrens inside, of little birds talking very fast, soft teak kinetic batteries.

Photograph of hall before ramp. The second washer is under the first. Put the chain through the gate not round the post. Leave the chair with the green seat beside the telephone. The clock in the photograph had stopped at ten twenty seven on the twenty eighth of December. There were other instructions, other notes, but whether these were written by Katita, like fragments of poetry on broken pots recovered from the bottom of the sea, letters rising, or authored by



the trees, by transmission lines, by rail lines in paired threads, bisecting land but not sky, this is what I will not discuss with my friend as the train brings me to the station at which I alight. From here to the outskirts of the bush where I will meet my friend it is a short walk. Behind the station there is a river with a suspension bridge that spans the gap. I take it to a dirt path that connects to another dirt path. His four-wheel drive is not in view, and then what do you know, turn the corner, there it is, surrounded by trees.

I see myself standing on a beachhead, kicking up sand with my footwork, gloves tight on my fists, sun setting, ring before me, the whole landscape on fire, like a lava lamp phasing and melting, and I pump my gloves together and take stock of my bearings and Katita places a wet washer over my head, she says Babe this is it, you've got this, look at you, this is everything you've been working towards. Win or lose, just enjoy knowing what you've accomplished to get here. I embrace her, my bare sweaty chest pushing into her cotton sundress, like data compressing, alligator clips on her ear lobes. Go, she says, and I step forwards onto a couch that I ride into the waves, through the ring, out towards where the sun bulbs, beyond the coal ships and beyond rain and batteries and cicadas and data centres and beyond all words. You are a ghost, I hear her call, Keep going, you are almost there. I am not a flower, she laughs, no I am not a rose or a billy button but rather I am tree, Leif, look at me grow, and she rises up from the sand and shades all horizons, and her roots absorb all oceans and I am an electrical pulse jitterbugging like a dust sprite into the air she breathes, and I breathe, and live forever.

```

#####=[ ]#####
My friend seems unaware of me until I'm just|
about to his car. He is standing beside a fence|
and is adjusting his sleeves, rolling the cuffs. |
I want him to ask me what it was    /\      |
like to be young, to be in love with  / \      |
everything all at once. We should  / ^^ \      |
talk about the pending war,  __/Mountain\__+_|
about the moral algorithms we should safe- |
guard, the boundary perimeters we  X START
should have in place, even just ethically. |
But that can wait. First we should just walk a |
while and talk about the surroundings here, |
the spot where our feet  ^^      |      ^^
got covered in slugs as  /||\    +---+    /||\
we slipped into the river beside    o      |
where the First Nations people  /Church\  |
of this country used to keep an  \/Radar\  |
armoury beneath the mountain. Behind    |
a grove of trees we sit and have some lunch, +
I packed sandwiches in my bag which we  --+
share and my friend does      ^^Bell Birds^^
not ask about Katita or what I  /||\      |  /||\
have been up to during the end of history but |
rather asks if I have been reading and I say yes
Their_Most_August_Public_Organ.txt FINISH

```

TRACE DELTA -1

/unverified/

Their\_Most\_August\_Public\_Organ.txt

I\_Love\_You.tmp

UPLOADED:

At meaning's edge the

imagination still flickers

CURRENT:

At meaning's edge the

imagination also flickers

DELTA:

- still

+ also

OUTGOING:

XOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOX

OXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXO

XOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOX

OXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXO

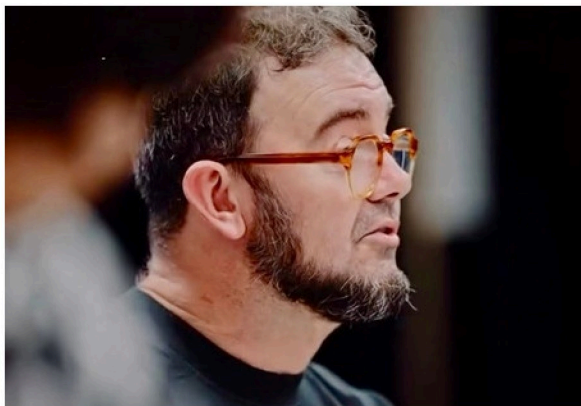
XOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOXOX

CHECKSUM:

unchanged



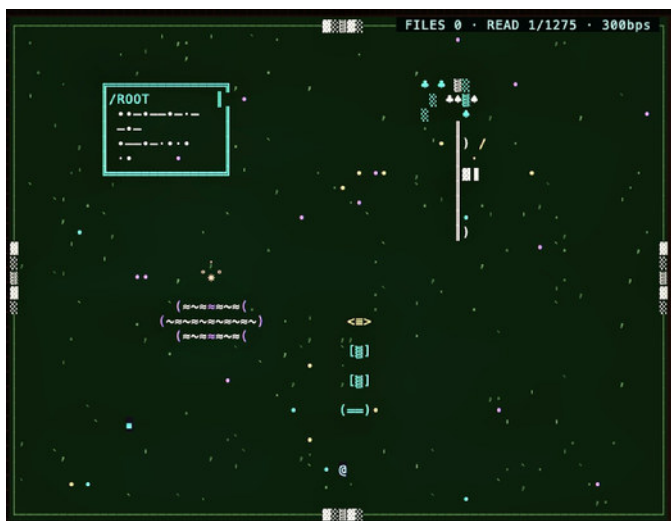




Craig Warren Smith lives in Hamilton, New South Wales, with his wife, daughter and son. He is a teacher and the author of the novel *A Complicated Surgery Will Take Place on the Beach Tonight* (2020), the filmed essay *Beyond Correct and Incorrect Nature* (2021), the novella *Antinomicity* (2022), the collection of short works *Postseasonal* (2023) and the selected works *Pastoral Scanlines* (2025).

*Their Most August Public Organ* is the second work in a trilogy. The first is *Everyone I Love Is Alive in the Unlimited Present of the City and Its Waters* (2025); the third, *Surplus of the Seen*, is in progress.

He records music as Wrenasmir, with the albums *Disjecta Songjiang '11-'15* (2016), *Oct Mod Var* (2020), *Aubadion* (2021), *Partimentodays* (2021) and *Telegraph* (2023). Selected tracks have appeared on compilations from the German label Bathurst.

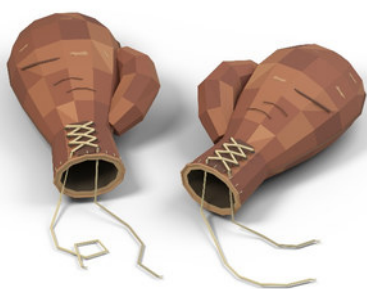


You can play a game I made called ROOT,  
based on this book, by going to:  
[root.wrenasmir.com](http://root.wrenasmir.com)

It is also available on the iOS App Store.



[illegible]



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